

• REC — LIVE FEED

The Panel and the Lens

A MOVIE RATIONALE

Recorded: 8 September 2026 · 18:14

Location: A hospital waiting room

Signal source: One unnamed channel, one thriller

Field notes on television, simulation, and the coldness behind the panel — from the great-grandson of Frank McCall Hursley, who wrote the soap opera General Hospital.

01 A HOSPITAL, A WAITING ROOM, A SCREEN

It was September 8, 2026, at 18:14. I was sitting in a hospital, waiting maybe thirty minutes, and there was a movie on. Some channel. And the thing is, I basically haven't watched television in so long. When I was younger I used to watch the Sci-Fi Channel, and that was a tight ship — not to be critical, but a lot of it was B-movies. Not even low budget, really; they had complex CGI, complex stories. I want to set the context for what I'm about to talk about.

02 THE CABIN, THE TOTEMS, THE PEOPLE BEHIND THE PANELS

Take the movie *Cabin in the Woods*. The young adults are set up in a scenario with different totems in the house. Depending on which one they knock over — breaking a doll, say — an elevator brings up a monster into their world, and it kills them. As the film goes on, it breaks the fourth wall. They're being monitored. There are people making a movie out of the deaths of these young adults, working from archetypes: the stoner, the ditzy hot girl, the smart hot girl, the jock, the nerd. Those archetypes have to die, once a year, or the gods are released to wreak havoc on the world.

I didn't see *that* film in the hospital. I bring it up because it taps the most beautiful reflection of modern television I know. What I can't unsee are the people behind the panels — the ones moving the cameras, catching the scenes of the kids dying, cold and apathetic about it, just trying to assemble a perfect feature film from whatever shots they have available. That perfect coldness. I've never been able to get it out of my mind.

The people behind the panels have no emotion about the killing. They are generating a movie from the scenes available to them. That is the image I can't unsee.

03 THE INHERITED GENE

This is coming from the great-grandson of Frank McCall Hursley, who wrote the soap opera *General Hospital*. I definitely got the writing-and-drama gene from that side — from my grandpa, Frank McCall Hursley Jr. Of anyone in the family, I'm the writer. Not from my dad's side; this is my mom's side. Nobody else on that side writes. I've made a habit of it for a long

time, and I like to think about behavioral economics and drama. When dramatic things happen in my life, I look at them from an extra-social perspective. That movie touched something in me I can't undo.

04 SOFT LIGHTING, FUSED GENRES, TOO MUCH INFORMATION

Why I bring up *General Hospital*: that soft lighting, the Hollywood way of filming soap operas, fused with sci-fi and then informed by action movies — that's what you get now on the average channel. And here's the thing — **I haven't watched TV in any major way since I was sixteen, and I'm thirty-three now.** I don't have one in my house. I think about how much information would come at me if I turned one on.

MARGINAL NOTE — THE YOUTH PASTOR

A youth pastor once joked that if someone from two thousand years ago came to our day and turned on a television or a computer, the sheer volume of information their mind would have to process would kill them. He was being hyperbolic, joking in a small group. But I completely agree. Just imagining flipping the channels makes me nervous. I've gone far into being able to sit alone in a room, pray, meditate, relax, explore my mind — and I want to pat myself on the back a little for separating from all of it.

05 THE REALNESS OF THE FACES

So I'm in the hospital looking at the TV, and it's a film — a low-budget one by today's standards, though what we call low budget now used to be high budget. A mix of action, soap opera, and thriller. Because I hadn't seen a movie on a television in so long, I looked into the faces of these people and it was so real. Their emotions, the situation they were facing — so real. In the back of my mind I kept rationalizing: this is just a movie, these are paid actors. But the fear, the surprise — I started to sense that the people engineering the events were putting the actors through genuinely stressful situations, manifesting real reactions.

06 THE BUILDING WHERE EVERY FLOOR IS A SET

I began building a story. What if there's a Hollywood building where every floor is a different set? All these films, like the one I was watching, set in some paneled room — almost a war room. It's like it all started with *Star Trek*: that open bridge, the captain's helm as a screen

instead of a wheel, people turning dials. In the film, they were hiding behind one of the panels while some killer closed in.

And I noticed there were almost no commercials — or maybe, because I was absorbing so much information, time was moving slowly for me. I entertained the thought: what if many sets of people were put through these thriller scenarios, and not everyone survives? Almost like *Saw* — people hunted down, captured, dropped into the scenario. What if Hollywood was hunting people down, running them through extremely stressful gauntlets, sapping them dry of emotion, and the ones who survive are the ones you later look up online?

You see the actress on the red carpet, star-struck into the camera, poised in a nice dress. That photograph is our modern statue — the immortalized image of someone who made it to the end of the gauntlet and kept a right head about themselves.

07 THE LENS, THE BLACK HOLE, THE MISSING EYES

Then I think about the camera, the lens — that black lens a podcaster looks into. They aren't talking to you; they're looking into a black hole with an odd eyeball in it. What do you have to have inside you to look into that eyeball and produce real reactions and emotion when nobody is looking back? All the context they have is feedback gathered elsewhere — from the internet, from comedy shows, from being in person, any way of getting real feedback from people.

08 ORGAN RESONATION AND THE ILLUSION OF FOLLOWERS

There's a disconnect between having followers in reality and having them online. A dog is sensitive to his owner's organs — any owner knows when he's upset. A shepherd of a hundred sheep is known by all of them. There's an organ resonation going on.

SOURCE — ANATOMY OF THE SPIRIT

Caroline Myss's *Anatomy of the Spirit* talks about the organs of the body holding onto emotions. A neurosurgeon I worked with in 11th grade gave me that book, said it was real, and talked about the anatomy of the spirit. The book describes people like Mother Teresa and Gandhi physically evolving by not holding onto anger, lust, jealousy — their organs evolved.

So people who think they have followers but get no organ resonance develop a deep dissonance, because they don't actually have followers. A king atop an Aztec pyramid with the crowd worshipping the sacrifice feels organ resonance. A rock star feels the crowd's energy in his organs. Movie stars, modern podcasters — especially the ones just talking into a camera, the Twitch streamers — don't get that in-reality resonance, and it's a critical part.

09 A TANGENT THAT MATTERS: THE SPECTRUM OF THE ORGANS

Each organ has a specific frequency — spectrums, like 98.3, 98.4 on the FM dial. At some point the spectrum markets that exist for radio might exist for organs. I imagine a device you bring to a rave that synchronizes everyone's liver, or pineal gland, jumping onto that spectrum. We can already buy FM spectrums — the real question is whether we can buy organ spectrums.

Shouldn't there be regulation so that even the government — the people with a monopoly on violence — can't own the spectrums of our organs? We should be free to resonate our organs how we want.

10 ACTING, CUES, AND THE ROLES WE ALREADY PLAY

Back to the hospital, watching this movie, so real. It had been even longer since I'd watched television television — flipping the channel — than since I'd seen a film. I played video games back then too, but once I got a car and could drive myself to go hang out with girls, I was done. Done with television, done with video games.

In that building where every floor is a set, there's the relationship between the set engineers — getting smarter, better at evoking emotion and reaction — and the actors, who've memorized their lines but stick to what the moment calls for, taking cues from what others say before them.

And there's a component of all this that is very much like reality: we play many roles, wear many hats, and communicate in sequential, almost procedural ways. We have our own moments of acting. As these settings get better at evoking the real thing, how much do the actors start to blend into actual situations — like the cabin in the woods?

11 RICK AND MORTY, AND THE LIGHT THAT GOES SOMEWHERE

To bring it full circle, one more pop reference. *Rick and Morty* had an episode about intergalactic television — cameras everywhere across the galaxy, so our day-to-day lives, just living and acting and speaking, send light somewhere. The light is always captured, if not here then over there.

I'm not saying there are hidden cameras everywhere like in the cabin. I'm saying there's no loss — the light goes somewhere. It's very possible that at certain moments in your life you are in someone else's TV set. Not literally someone behind a monitor watching you.

EARTHLY FRAME — RESPONSIBILITY

In that earthly context, what we do is more like a file: certain actions and trigger points and thresholds get surpassed, certain language and behaviors fill up, and you reach another risk level. It loops back to insurance as governance, and the equation:

$$R = I / N$$

Responsibility equals Intention divided by Negligence — man-made insurance, man-made economics, plus surveillance, plus self-reporting traceable online. But I'm not really talking about the man-made things. I mean the galactic sense that *Rick and Morty* brings out: day-to-day life being seen.

12 THE SIN OF OMISSION BETWEEN THE SCENES

One more key component: any time the scene changes — any angle change, not just a full cut — you don't know how much time passed. We impose continuity onto it. There's a complete sin of omission when we watch: anything could have happened between the moments the angle changed. The person could have gone to the bathroom, smoked a cigarette, eaten, gone home, slept, come back. We recognize countenance and temperament scene by scene, but we take that continuity for granted.

13 HOW DO YOU KNOW FOR SURE?

Some of these films are so realistic that I get the sense — how do you know for sure these aren't people in real-life scenarios, and we're just apathetically consuming it? I was on fire. My dendrites, my attention completely on fire, watching this thriller, astonished by the acting.

The one thing that made me think it was low budget was that the actors didn't seem that professional — as if the engineers were the professionals, making good actors out of anyone because the scenarios were so real to them.

So that's a little bit of an exposé, if you will. The state of television and movies, from the great-grandson of Frank McCall Hursley — the writer of the soap opera *General Hospital* — and my honest perspective on the state of things.

14 BUT WHY DO WE FLOOD OUR MINDS?

Less what I'm trying to say, but important: why do we put ourselves through this much information — not just the actors, but us, the viewers? Why flood our minds with all these simulated scenarios? Simulation is probably the best word. It taps some of my dreams about places like Las Vegas, and it makes me ask: why don't we consider ourselves to be experiencing a vantage point on seriously intense situations?

The whole thing I'm trying to stay away from is asking whether it's realistic. I think we've gone too far into rationalizing that it's *not*. For all intents and purposes, this is very real. Everything the actors go through, everything we go through consuming the information — it's burning out our ability to empathize with the real world if it actually happens, our ability to hold our spirit, our emotions, our logic. Just because we don't meet these things daily doesn't mean we could handle them if we did, and it doesn't mean we shouldn't care for the people putting themselves through these scenarios.

That said, everyone in these movies is a consenting adult, as far as I know. So...

— END OF TRANSMISSION —